



Spin wiz:

Afghanistan's ace up its sleeve has been its spin bowling attack, led by the maverick Rashid Khan. GETTY IMAGES

Ready to fire the opening salvo

Afghanistan's success in limited-overs cricket has been **largely due to** the success of its openers and spinners.

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The 2024 T20 World Cup in the West Indies and USA demonstrated that Afghanistan is no longer just making up the numbers.

The incredible talent pool in the country's reserves, coupled with the experience they

have gained by playing cricket in leagues around the world, has made the team a serious contender to go deep into ICC tournaments.

The Hashmatullah Shahidi-led team has performed exceptionally well since the 50-over World Cup in India in 2023, where it earned wins

against England and Pakistan and took Australia to the brink, only to end up facing the wrath of a certain Glenn Maxwell.

In five bilateral series since the ODI World Cup, Afghanistan has won four, including one against South Africa in the UAE.

The Afghan Atalan's only loss came in an away tour against Sri Lanka, where they were batted out of contention by Pathum Nissanka.

Afghanistan's success in limited-overs cricket has been built on the platform provided by its openers, Rahmanullah Gurbaz and Ibrahim Zadran.

The two right-handers have combined for 1,514 runs in 31 ODI matches, averaging a partnership of 48.83 per game.

The duo is placed second on the all-time partnership list for the country, behind Rahmat Shah and Shahidi, who will bat at three and four — indicating the consistency the top order possesses.

There is no shortage of power-hitting in the middle order as well. Gulbadin Naib is entering the competition on the back of a stupendous return in the International League T20, where he scored 381 runs at an average of 45 and a strike rate of nearly 160.

Afghanistan's ace up its sleeve has been its spin bowling attack, led by the maverick Rashid Khan. Shahidi has quite a few options to tinker with in this department.

The overload of spin-bowling talent means Mujeeb-ur-Rahman, who impressed in the recently concluded SA20 tournament, doesn't find a place in the squad.

Noor Ahmad and Allah Ghazanfar will vie for a place in the playing eleven, partnering Rashid and veteran Mohammad Nabi, who could be playing his last 50-over international tournament for his country.

Ghazanfar has had a brilliant start to his international career, picking up 21 wickets in 11 ODIs in 2024, while Noor continues to be efficient in his performances across the